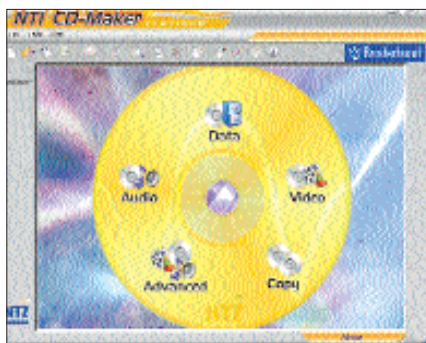




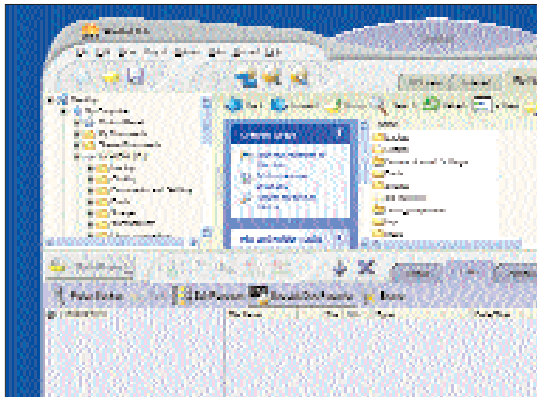
NTI CD-Maker has a creative interface that makes working with it a pleasure

any wizards as such, but the interface is intuitive enough to not need one. It can burn CDs from ISO images and create ISO images too. CD-Maker supports all popular CD formats, including mixed-mode CD and CD Extra. Music CD creation is supported in the MP3 and WMA formats; Creating a bootable CD is not possible, however. With Build Video CD, you can create a VCD from MPEG and even AVI files. It does the required encoding before writing it onto your CD, which can then be played on any VCD player. It supports packet-writing through FileCD, with the ease of drag-and-drop. It comes with a CD label creator. Other utilities include a music player and a WAVE editor.

This software supports recording of sound from a microphone or any other line input, directly onto CD. CD-Maker 6 had one significant disadvantage—it did not detect five out of eight drives during our compatibility test, so beware! Get this software only if ease of use is your primary concern—and if you have a compatible CD-Writer.

WinOnCD 6 Power Edition

The file browser in WinOnCD is easy to use, and supports network browsing. Creating VCDs and Audio CDs is simple—just select the files, do the editing you need to, using the provided video and audio editor, and click the record button. WinOnCD supports data and video spanning too. You can create bootable and auto-play disks using its in-built options. It also supports the MAC file system. This program has an integrated Web browser, and with this, you can write music files directly from any music server. It can also search for music files and MP3 ID3 tags on a server. It has an audio grabber with jitter correction for saving audio tracks from CDs onto hard disk. Overall, WinOnCD is good for novice users, but it can be a bit unfriendly.



Choose WinONCD for its easy network browsing

Wrap-up

From the comparison tests, it's clear that all the software manufacturers are trying to make their products as user-friendly as possible. The effect is that user-friendliness has reached such a level that even a 10-year-old can easily operate a CD-Writer, using such software as NTI CD-Maker and Easy CD/DVD Creator.

NTI CD-Maker showed incompatibility with many popular CD drives. RecordNow Max turned out to be the least resource hungry, and Nero the most. Pinnacle Instant CD/DVD is a relative newcomer, but it performed surprisingly well, and gave Nero a tough fight. Without a doubt, Instant CD/DVD is the best software for multimedia professionals, but in the end, Nero 6, with its new interface and aplenty options, emerged the overall winner.

Short bytes

There are several small and simple utilities available that do a particular job well. We take a look at some of these:

Blaze Audio RipEditBurn 2.10: A

complete solution for music enthusiasts, it can rip tracks from audio CDs, and edit them too. The WAV editor can be used for removing hiss and periods of silence. RipEditBurn supports a number of effects that can be applied onto the WAV file, such as amplify, echo, fade-in, fade-out, chorus and so on. You can even convert your tapes into digital format.

The interface is easy to use. After ripping and editing, you can create MP3 and RealAudio files, and then burn them onto CDs using the provided minimalist writer.

VCDEasy 1.1.6: If you have a large video collection on your hard disk, and want to convert them into VCDs, VCDEasy is the perfect utility for you. It has all the features you need for creating VCDs and SVCDs from BIN and ISO files. It has several advanced options, but for the basic user, creating VCDs is as simple as selecting files and clicking a button. Besides creating VCDs, you can rip VCDs and store them as MPEG files. You can convert DAT files to true MPEG files, but VCDEasy cannot convert AVI to MPEG. For professionals, VCDEasy has features such as customised gaps and fillings, playback control, editing CD-I configuration files and much more.

Burn-to-the Brim 2.6.1: When you want to back up a large number of files on one or more CDs, finding a combination from those files to fill up a perfect CD can be a difficult task. Burn-to-the Brim helps you with that. All you have to do is select the folder that you want to back up, and the tool will

Packet writing

Packet writing is a technique by which a normal CD-R or CD-RW can be used like a floppy or zip drive. You can save an MS Word document, or any file directly onto the CD whenever you want. Normally, when a CD is burned, the table of content (ToC) is generated first, then the burning begins, and finally the ToC is written onto it. This allows the OS to retrieve the files from the CD the way it is meant to be, but once the ToC is burnt in, more data can't be written onto the CD. The idea behind packet writing is that if one need not worry about the TOC, one can write data to a CD-R in blocks or packets. By

writing an appropriate set of functions into the OS, a vendor can provide packet capability for writers with suitable hardware and firmware. However since the ToC will not present the usual way, the ToC information has to be conveyed to the OS in some other manner. This is done by including a header along with each packet that contains the information on the file it represents, including its length. This also tells the OS where the next packet begins. In this way the OS can read the CD contents. However, adding this additional information decreases the disc's capacity.